

Young Goodman Brown

Nathaniel Hawthorne · 1835

First published: New-England Magazine, Apr 1835

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Mosses_from_an_Old_Manse/Young_Goodman_Brown (revision 8986229), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Young Goodman Brown suggest about faith and doubt?
- What does Young Goodman Brown suggest about hypocrisy?
- What does Young Goodman Brown suggest about the nature of evil?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	Young Goodman Brown	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*faith and doubt* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Young Goodman Brown

Focus: the loss of faith in human goodness

Content note (witchcraft, devil figure): Sensitive content: Witchcraft; devil figure. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes witchcraft; devil figure.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

In Puritan Salem, Goodman Brown leaves his new wife Faith for a night errand in the forest, where he walks with a traveler resembling his own grandfather, carrying a serpent-like staff. He sees pious townspeople, his minister and finally Faith herself gathering for a witches' communion. He cries out for Faith to resist and finds himself alone. Whether dream or not, he lives out his life gloomy and distrustful, and 'his dying hour was gloom.'

Background: Hawthorne (1835) was descended from John Hathorne, a judge at the 1692 Salem witch trials.

Significance: An allegory central to American literature courses; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: What would happen to you if you came to believe everyone you trust is secretly bad? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes witchcraft; devil figure.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are nettled, intercepted, auditor, composedly, meditate. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "considerably nettled, "there is my wife, Faith." In this sentence it means: irritated; annoyed. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of Young Goodman Brown would have known. Hawthorne (1835) was descended from John Hathorne, a judge at the 1692 Salem witch trials. Why does this story matter? An allegory central to American literature courses; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for allusion.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "They continued to walk onward, while the elder traveller exhorted his companion to make good speed and persevere in the path, discoursing so aptly that his arguments seemed rather to spring up in the bosom of his auditor" I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to the loss of faith in human goodness? I circle "auditor", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find allusion, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for allusion.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of allusion. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *They continued to walk onward, while the elder traveller exhorted his companion to make good speed and persevere in the path, discoursing so aptly that his arguments seemed rather to spring up in the bosom of his auditor than to be suggested by himself. As they went, he plucked a branch of maple to serve for a walking stick, and began to strip it of the twigs and little boughs, which were wet with evening dew. The moment his fingers touched them they became strangely withered and dried up as with a week's sunshine. Thus the pair proceeded, at a good free pace, until suddenly, in a gloomy hollow of the road, Goodman Brown sat himself down on the stump of a tree and refused to go any farther.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Allusion, Symbolism, Setting: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how Young Goodman Brown develops the idea of the loss of faith in human goodness. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of allusion and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to faith and doubt? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about the loss of faith in human goodness, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how allusion shapes the loss of faith in human goodness. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
nettled (adjective)	irritated; annoyed	*considerably nettled, "there is my wife, Faith.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
intercepted (verb)	seize on its way	*Though their figures brushed the small boughs by the wayside, it could not be seen that they intercepted, even for a moment, the faint gleam from the strip of bright sky athwart which they must have passed.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
auditor (noun)	someone who listens attentively	*They continued to walk onward, while the elder traveller exhorted his companion to make good speed and persevere in the path, discoursing so aptly that his arguments seemed rather to spring up in the bosom of his auditor than to be suggested by himself.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
composedly (adverb)	in a self-collected or self-possessed manner	*composedly. "Sit here and rest yourself a while; and when you*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
meditate (verb)	reflect deeply on a subject	*The good old minister was taking a walk along the graveyard to get an appetite for breakfast and meditate his sermon, and bestowed a blessing, as he passed, on Goodman Brown.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
persevere (verb)	be persistent, refuse to stop	*They continued to walk onward, while the elder traveller exhorted his companion to make good speed and persevere in the path, discoursing so aptly that his arguments seemed rather to spring up in the bosom of his auditor than to be suggested by himself.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
crouched (verb)	bend one's back forward from the waist on down	*Goodman Brown alternately crouched and stood on tiptoe, pulling aside the branches and thrusting forth his head as far as he durst without discerning so much as a shadow.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
doubting (verb)	feeling unsure	*He looked up to the sky, doubting whether there really was a heaven above him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
conversing (verb)	carry on a conversation	*On came the hoof tramps and the voices of the riders, two grave old voices, conversing soberly as they drew near.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

considerably (adverb)	to a great extent or degree	*considerably nettled, "there is my wife, Faith.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What would happen to you if you came to believe everyone you trust is secretly bad?
2. Where does allusion appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with faith and doubt?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the name of Brown's wife? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Faith
2. What does the traveler carry? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A staff that looks like a twisting serpent
3. Whom does Brown see in the forest? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Pious townspeople and his minister
4. What does Brown find on a branch? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A pink ribbon from Faith's cap
5. How does Brown live after that night? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Stern, sad and distrustful until death
6. Retell the three most important events of “Young Goodman Brown” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: In Puritan Salem, Goodman Brown leaves his new wife Faith for a night errand in the forest, where he walks with a traveler resembling his own grandfather, carrying a serpent-like staff. He sees pious townspeople, his minister and finally Faith herself gathering for a witches' communion. He cries out for Faith to resist and finds himself alone. Whether dream or not, he lives out his life gloomy…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Young Goodman Brown”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “Young Goodman Brown” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “considerably nettled, "there is my wife, Faith.” What does “nettled” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: nettled: irritated; annoyed.

10. Reread: “Though their figures brushed the small boughs by the wayside, it could not be seen that they intercepted, even for a moment, the faint gleam from the strip of bright sky athwart which they must have passed.” What does “intercepted” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: intercepted: seize on its way.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Young Goodman Brown” suggest about the loss of faith in human goodness? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: An allegory central to American literature courses; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1.
2. Find one example of allusion in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for references to other books, myths, history or religion.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about the loss of faith in human goodness? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
4. In the passage that begins “They continued to walk onward, while the elder traveller exhorted his companion to make good speed and persevere in the path, discoursing so aptly that his arguments seemed rather…”, why might Hawthorne have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Young Goodman Brown”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: In Puritan Salem, Goodman Brown leaves his new wife Faith for a night errand in the forest, where he walks with a traveler resembling his own grandfather, carrying a serpent-like staff. He sees pious townspeople, his minister and finally Faith herself gathering for a witches' communion. He cries…
6. As the opening story, what does “Young Goodman Brown” set up that the rest of Young Goodman Brown will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What would happen to you if you came to believe everyone you trust is secretly bad?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does setting appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with faith and doubt? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
10. Background: Hawthorne (1835) was descended from John Hathorne, a judge at the 1692 Salem witch trials. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “An allegory central to American literature courses; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Young Goodman Brown” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the loss of faith in human goodness? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “Young Goodman Brown”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to hypocrisy: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Hawthorne need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the allusion in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “Young Goodman Brown” treats the loss of faith in human goodness with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Young Goodman Brown see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve faith and doubt? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the loss of faith in human goodness? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Nathaniel Hawthorne about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Allusion:** look for references to other books, myths, history or religion (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling

Chapter quiz

1. What is the name of Brown's wife?

   A. Hope

   B. Faith

C. Prudence

D. Charity

2. What does the traveler carry?

A. A staff that looks like a twisting serpent

B. A lantern

C. A Bible

D. A sword

3. Whom does Brown see in the forest?

A. Pious townspeople and his minister

B. Only strangers

C. No one

D. Indians only

4. What does Brown find on a branch?

A. A pink ribbon from Faith's cap

B. A feather

C. A letter

D. A cross

5. How does Brown live after that night?

A. As an exile

B. Stern, sad and distrustful until death

C. As a minister

D. Happily with Faith

6. In the line “considerably nettled, "there is my wife, Faith.”, what does “nettled” most nearly mean?

A. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

B. irritated; annoyed

C. someone who listens attentively

D. seize on its way

7. In the line “Though their figures brushed the small boughs by the wayside, it could not be seen that they intercepted, even for a moment, the faint gleam from the strip of bright sky athwart which they must have passed.”, what does “intercepted” most nearly mean?

A. seize on its way

B. someone who listens attentively

C. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

D. irritated; annoyed

Answer key: 1. B (Faith); 2. A (A staff that looks like a twisting serpent); 3. A (Pious townspeople and his minister); 4. A (A pink ribbon from Faith's cap); 5. B (Stern, sad and distrustful until death); 6. B (irritated; annoyed); 7. A (seize on its way)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.2, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.2, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Young Goodman Brown," how does Hawthorne show the loss of faith in human goodness? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the allusion you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.9, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In Young Goodman Brown, how does Hawthorne develop the idea of the loss of faith in human goodness? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the allusion in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.9, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how Young Goodman Brown develops the idea of the loss of faith in human goodness. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of allusion and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of Young Goodman Brown (where it begins, turns and ends) and its allusion shape the reader's understanding of the loss of faith in human goodness. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.2, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what Young Goodman Brown suggests about the loss of faith in human goodness. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's allusion and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.2, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Nathaniel Hawthorne uses allusion in Young Goodman Brown to complicate the reader's understanding of the loss of faith in human goodness. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Young Goodman Brown within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the loss of faith in human goodness responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Young Goodman Brown alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the loss of faith in human goodness follows or bends those conventions, using the allusion as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Young Goodman Brown and its treatment of the loss of faith in human goodness. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's allusion and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Young Goodman Brown as evidence for a larger claim about the loss of faith in human goodness in Young Goodman Brown. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Young Goodman Brown as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the loss of faith in human goodness. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Young Goodman Brown.

SAT-style questions

1. *They continued to walk onward, while the elder traveller exhorted his companion to make good speed and persevere in the path, discoursing so aptly that his arguments seemed rather to spring up in the bosom of his auditor than to be suggested by himself.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “auditor” most nearly mean?

   A. carry on a conversation

   B. someone who listens attentively

   C. to a great extent or degree

   D. feeling unsure

2. *They continued to walk onward, while the elder traveller exhorted his companion to make good speed and persevere in the path, discoursing so aptly that his arguments seemed rather to spring up in the bosom of his auditor than to be suggested by himself. As they went, he plucked a branch of maple to serve for a walking stick, and began to strip it of the twigs and little boughs, which were wet with evening dew. The moment his fingers touched them they became strangely withered and dried up as with a week's sunshine. Thus the pair proceeded, at a good free pace, until suddenly, in a gloomy hollow of the road, Goodman Brown sat himself down on the stump of a tree and refused to go any farther.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Young Goodman Brown”?

   A. A reversal that punishes a change of heart

   B. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

   C. Guilt that the mind cannot hide

   D. The loss of faith in human goodness

SAT key: 1. B (someone who listens attentively); 2. D (The loss of faith in human goodness)

Whole-book test

Young Goodman Brown: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What is the name of Brown's wife?
   A. Hope
   B. Faith
   C. Prudence
   D. Charity
2. What does the traveler carry?
   A. A staff that looks like a twisting serpent
   B. A lantern
   C. A Bible
   D. A sword
3. Whom does Brown see in the forest?
   A. Pious townspeople and his minister
   B. Only strangers
   C. No one
   D. Indians only
4. What does Brown find on a branch?
   A. A pink ribbon from Faith's cap
   B. A feather
   C. A letter
   D. A cross
5. How does Brown live after that night?
   A. As an exile
   B. Stern, sad and distrustful until death
   C. As a minister
   D. Happily with Faith
6. In the line “considerably nettled, "there is my wife, Faith.”, what does “nettled” most nearly mean?
   A. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
   B. irritated; annoyed
   C. someone who listens attentively
   D. seize on its way

7. In the line “Though their figures brushed the small boughs by the wayside, it could not be seen that they intercepted, even for a moment, the faint gleam from the strip of bright sky athwart which they must have passed.”, what does “intercepted” most nearly mean?
   A. seize on its way
   B. someone who listens attentively
   C. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
   D. irritated; annoyed
8. As used in the story (“considerably nettled, "there is my wife, Faith.”), what does “nettled” mean?
   A. irritated; annoyed
   B. reflect deeply on a subject
   C. feeling unsure
   D. seize on its way
9. As used in the story (“Though their figures brushed the small boughs by the wayside, it could not be seen that they intercepted, even for a moment, the faint gleam”), what does “intercepted” mean?
   A. be persistent, refuse to stop
   B. seize on its way
   C. carry on a conversation
   D. someone who listens attentively
10. As used in the story (“They continued to walk onward, while the elder traveller exhorted his companion to make good speed and persevere in the path, discoursing so”), what does “auditor” mean?
    A. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
    B. to a great extent or degree
    C. someone who listens attentively
    D. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
11. As used in the story (“composedly. "Sit here and rest yourself a while; and when you”), what does “composedly” mean?
    A. feeling unsure
    B. irritated; annoyed
    C. reflect deeply on a subject
    D. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
12. As used in the story (“The good old minister was taking a walk along the graveyard to get an appetite for breakfast and meditate his sermon, and bestowed a blessin”), what does “meditate” mean?
    A. reflect deeply on a subject
    B. carry on a conversation
    C. seize on its way
    D. be persistent, refuse to stop

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how faith and doubt develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how hypocrisy develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how the nature of evil develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (faith and doubt, hypocrisy, the nature of evil) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. B (Faith); 2. A (A staff that looks like a twisting serpent); 3. A (Pious townspeople and his minister); 4. A (A pink ribbon from Faith's cap); 5. B (Stern, sad and distrustful until death); 6. B (irritated; annoyed); 7. A (seize on its way); 8. A (irritated; annoyed); 9. B (seize on its way); 10. C (someone who listens attentively); 11. D (in a self-collected or self-possessed manner); 12. A (reflect deeply on a subject)

Essay assignments

Essay: Faith and doubt

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Young Goodman Brown teaches about faith and doubt. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops faith and doubt in Young Goodman Brown. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops faith and doubt across Young Goodman Brown. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Young Goodman Brown (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of faith and doubt. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of faith and doubt in Young Goodman Brown. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in Young Goodman Brown (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of faith and doubt, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Young Goodman Brown's treatment of faith and doubt in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on faith and doubt in Young Goodman Brown that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on faith and doubt in Young Goodman Brown. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about faith and doubt in Young Goodman Brown, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on faith and doubt in Young Goodman Brown, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Hypocrisy

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Young Goodman Brown teaches about hypocrisy. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops hypocrisy in Young Goodman Brown. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops hypocrisy across Young Goodman Brown. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Young Goodman Brown (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of hypocrisy. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of hypocrisy in Young Goodman Brown. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in Young Goodman Brown (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of hypocrisy, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Young Goodman Brown's treatment of hypocrisy in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on hypocrisy in Young Goodman Brown that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on hypocrisy in Young Goodman Brown. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about hypocrisy in Young Goodman Brown, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on hypocrisy in Young Goodman Brown, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The nature of evil

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Young Goodman Brown teaches about the nature of evil. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops the nature of evil in Young Goodman Brown. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops the nature of evil across Young Goodman Brown. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Young Goodman Brown (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the nature of evil. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the nature of evil in Young Goodman Brown. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in Young Goodman Brown (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the nature of evil, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Young Goodman Brown's treatment of the nature of evil in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the nature of evil in Young Goodman Brown that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the nature of evil in Young Goodman Brown. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the nature of evil in Young Goodman Brown, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the nature of evil in Young Goodman Brown, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.